

LESSON GUIDE

Proportions

Proportion is the relationship between the sizes of different elements in a drawing. A drawing with correct perspective and beautiful line quality still fails if the proportions are wrong. This lesson teaches systematic measurement methods that produce consistent accuracy.

4-WEEK PLAN

Week 1 — The Comparative Method

Choose one element as your unit of measurement. Measure every other element relative to it using your pencil held at arm's length. Practice with still life objects.

Week 2 — Figure Proportions

Draw a standing figure using the head as the measuring unit. A typical figure is 7 to 7.5 heads tall. Place landmarks at the correct head-unit positions.

Week 3 — Sighting & Plumb Lines

Use vertical and horizontal sighting lines to check alignment of elements in a composition. Identify what is directly above, below, left, or right of each landmark.

Week 4 — Foreshortening

Draw a hand or foot pointing directly toward you. Measure the foreshortened dimensions carefully — the compressed form will look completely different from expected.

KEY CONCEPTS

The Comparative Method

Measuring elements against each other using a pencil at arm's length. The most reliable on-the-spot proportioning tool available to any artist.

Human Figure Proportions

The standard figure is 7 to 7.5 head-heights tall. Hips at 4 heads, knees at 5.5, ankles at 7.5. Heroic proportions push to 8 or 9 heads.

Head Proportions

Eyes sit at the exact vertical midpoint of the head. The nose base falls at the midpoint between eyes and chin. The mouth is roughly one-third above the chin.

Sighting & Plumb Lines

Imaginary vertical and horizontal lines dropped from key points to reveal what aligns with what. Essential for checking spatial relationships.

Foreshortening

The visual compression of a form pointing toward the viewer. Foreshortened dimensions are dramatically shorter than you expect, requiring direct measurement.

Proportion Errors & Fixes

Systematic approaches to identifying and correcting the most common proportion errors: eyes too high, arms too short, hands too small.

ESSENTIAL RESOURCES

- Proko — Figure proportions and measurement series (YouTube)
- Andrew Loomis — Figure Drawing for All It's Worth (free on Archive.org)
- Drawing on the Right Side of the Brain — Betty Edwards (sighting methods)
- New Masters Academy — Comparative measurement demonstrations
- Line of Action — quickposes.com for figure proportion practice